

THE LIFESTYLE OF THE TYPICAL AMERICAN MILLIONAIRE

Is a show about the typical American millionaire one the mass TV audience would enjoy? We doubt it. Why not? Let's take a look at why not.

The camera zooms in on the typical millionaire household of Mr. Johnny Lucas. Like most millionaires, Johnny, fifty-seven, has been married to the same woman for most of his adult life. He holds an undergraduate degree from a local college. He is the owner of a small janitorial contracting firm that has thrived in the last few years. All of his workers now wear nicely tailored uniforms, including hats that bear his company's logo.

To his neighbors, Johnny and his family appear to be nondescript, middle-class folks, but Johnny has a net worth of more than \$2 million. In fact, in terms of wealth, Johnny's household ranks in the top 10 percent of all the households in his "nice neighborhood." Nationwide, his household is in the top 2 percent.

How will the TV audience respond to the description of Johnny's wealth and the images of Johnny on the screen? First, viewers will likely be confused, because Johnny does not look like the millionaire most people envision. Second, they may be uncomfortable. Johnny's traditional family values and his lifestyle of hard work, discipline, sacrifice, thrift, and sound investment habits might threaten the audience. What happens when you tell the average American adult that he needs to reduce his spending in order to build wealth for the future? He may perceive this as a threat to his way of life. It is likely that only Johnny and his cohorts would tune in to such a program. It would certainly bolster their views about life.

In spite of these concerns, let us assume that one of the major TV networks agrees to run at least a pilot program about the Johnnys of America. What will this program tell the viewing audience?

Here is Johnny Lucas, ladies and gentlemen. Mr. Lucas is a millionaire. I will ask Johnny some questions about his